

A JAPANESE WAVE: EXAMINING JAPANESE POPULAR MUSIC IN THE WEST AND
ITS INFLUENCE ON WESTERN POPULAR MUSIC

by

Kyle Hutcheson

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Nico Schüler

ABSTRACT

Beginning with the “British Invasion” in the 1960s and continuing throughout the 1990s, Western popular music from both the United Kingdom and the United States made its way to Japan and became immensely popular, essentially shaping the Japanese popular music industry into what it is today. However, several decades out from this phenomenon, with ample time for Japanese musicians to have developed their own styles and genres, and with the increasing globalization of the world in recent decades, is it possible that the reverse is occurring with Japanese popular music becoming increasingly popular in the West? In this thesis, I aim to describe the extent to which Japanese popular music has influenced Western musicians, especially within the past several years. With a focus on three genres that have their roots in Japan, namely chillhop (also known as lo-fi hip hop), city pop, and Japanese noise music, I examine both sonic and visual traits (specifically regarding things like album art and/or music videos) within these genres and connect them to similar traits that have emerged more recently within Western popular music. As this phenomenon of Japanese popular music influencing Western popular music is still in its infancy, the scale at which Western musicians have actually been influenced is still somewhat small, but there is also the possibility that as time goes on, further scholarly attention on this topic, especially focusing on different musical genres, may yield different or potentially greater results.

DEDICATION

To my late grandmother Phyllis Belben, who greatly enriched and encouraged my interest in Japanese culture. Thank you forever.

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I. A WESTERN WAVE: THE RISE IN POPULARITY OF WESTERN MUSIC IN JAPAN FROM THE 1960s TO THE 1990s

I.1 Japanese Popular Music Before and During the 1950s

In general, the Japanese popular music industry before the late 1950s consisted mostly of genres such as *enka* (Japanese ballads) and folk music, among others grouped under the umbrella term *kayokyoku*, which has been used to describe domestic popular music since the 1920s. Several elements of these types of music, especially in early *kayokyoku*, have roots in traditional Japanese music and poetry. More specifically, the musical structure follows the pentatonic scale, or *yonanuki* (literally meaning removing the fourth and seventh notes of a scale),¹ and singers of *kayokyoku* use specific trembling voice techniques called *yuri*, a common technique in traditional Japanese singing.² The lyrical structure follows a fixed verse form, specifically a seven and five syllable meter reminiscent of traditional Japanese poetry like *haiku* and *waka*.³ After Japan's surrender in World War II, the country fell under occupation of the United States, who would go on to take control of the Japanese government for just over a decade. The impact this occupation had was not only felt in the political and economic sphere, but also in the cultural sphere as well. Many different aspects of Japanese culture changed as a result of the influence that the United States had on Japan, including music. Within the next few paragraphs, I will discuss what effects this influence had on the Japanese popular music industry from the 1960s to the 1990s, as well as how the Japanese music industry changed and evolved as a result of this influence through the modification of Western styles of music such as hip-hop, and the fusion of multiple different

¹ Judith Ann Herd, "Trends and Taste in Japanese Popular Music: A Case-Study of the 1982 Yamaha World Popular Music Festival," *Popular Music* 4 (1984); 80.

² Junko Kitagawa, "Some Aspects of Japanese Popular Music," *Popular Music* 10, no. 3 (October 1991); 305.

³ *Ibid.*, 305.

genres to create something entirely new in the form of *Shibuya-kei* music.

I.2 Western Influence in Japanese Pop Music from the 1960s-1990s

The beginning of the 1960s saw the rock'n'roll craze sweep over Japan, where many Japanese people began to listen to more rock'n'roll artists from outside their own country, namely Elvis Presley and the Beatles. Along with rock'n'roll, other Western musics like jazz also began to influence Japanese *kayokyoku*, both through specific musical aspects as well as through the number of amateur artists that entered the industry. Where the sense of time in early *kayokyoku* was likely a lot more subtle and the music was built around the pentatonic scale, the music in post-1950 *kayokyoku* had much more overt beats and a pervading sense of pulse throughout, and the music itself was built around the Western diatonic scale.⁴ This shift in the tonal qualities of *kayokyoku* exemplifies the influence that Western music had on Japanese music. In addition, more and more people began to make music as developments in technology began to make music more accessible to the general public, and a lot of these people got their start imitating popular Western artists.

If the 1960s were characterized by shifts within the industry towards the production of “Western-style” *kayokyoku*, the 1970s were characterized by shifts throughout the public towards increased listening and consumption of Western pop music as well as the aforementioned “Western-style” *kayokyoku*. Junko Kitagawa references the lyrics of the band Southern All-Stars as representative of this shift in listening patterns, noting in particular that these lyrics strayed away from the traditional role of lyrics as seen in early *kayokyoku* as “a meaningfully constructed entity” telling a story; rather, these lyrics are instead taken as a part of the sound.⁵

⁴ Kitagawa, “Some Aspects,” 306.

⁵ Kitagawa, “Some Aspects,” 306.

The lyrics themselves are often repeated and don't really make a whole lot of sense, but this is helpful in taking the listener's attention off of the lyrics to instead have them focus on the sound of the music as a whole: Kitagawa describes this as a shift from "personal-oriented listening" to "sound-oriented listening."⁶ As mentioned before, the 1970s along with the 1980s also saw an increase in the public's consumption of Western music, as well as "Western-style" *kayokyoku*. For example, by 1989, the consumption of *ho-ban*, or records by Japanese artists, made up 64.7 percent of the entire market, while consumption of *yo-ban*, or records by Western artists, made up 35.3 percent of the market.⁷ This is a significant number, considering that only a few decades prior, *yo-ban* practically did not exist in the Japanese market.

The 1980s generally continued the trends discussed earlier that began in the 1960s and 1970s, but one important shift that began within this decade was related to the behaviors of consumers. As specific singers grew in popularity, people began to form fan clubs devoted to the research of their favorite singers or idols, which was especially prevalent with the formation of large idol groups like *Onyanko Club*, and this trend can still be seen today.⁸ Other shifts that occurred during this decade were the development of technology to make listening to music more accessible through cassette tapes, as well as an increasing importance in music education among Japanese youth. Music classes became more desirable for parents, who often enrolled their sons and daughters in classes or private lessons beginning as early as three years old.⁹ These gradual shifts in attitudes towards popular music ultimately led to an acceptance and promotion of a culture of imitation and mimicry within amateur Japanese artists, in which young artists would often make covers of songs by other Japanese artists or even Western artists,

⁶ Ibid., 306-7.

⁷ Shigeru Kawabata, "The Japanese Record Industry," *Popular Music* 10, no. 3 (October 1991): 335.

⁸ Kitagawa, "Some Aspects," 308.

⁹ Ibid., 310.

engaging in the interpretation and creation of an extensive library of music that was becoming more and more readily available to Japanese youth.

While many artists may have gotten their start performing covers and mimicking other artists and building a knowledge of musical styles and idioms, as they continue their career, they utilize this knowledge they develop to create something entirely new. The next few sections will examine different cases in which this process has occurred in Japan, first through Japanese rap and hip-hop, which emerged as a branch from its Western forerunner, and next through the *Shibuya-kei* genre, which can be described as a fusion of many different musical styles, both from Japan and the West.

I.3 Japanese Rap and Hip-Hop: Overcoming a Language Barrier

One genre of Japanese popular music where we can see a lot of direct influence from the West as well as innovation on the part of Japanese artists is in the creation of Japanese hip-hop and rap music. Groups such as Scha Dara Parr, King Giddra, RIP Slyme, Mellow Yellow, Rhymester, and others who may be considered as some of the forefathers of Japanese rap and enjoyed breakout success starting in the late 1990s cite several different influences, notable among them being American rappers/rap groups like NAS, Run-DMC, A Tribe Called Quest, and Public Enemy, just to name a few.¹⁰ The music made by these Western artists served as the framework for the early Japanese rappers to “study” and reference as they created their own music. However, as rap and hip-hop are heavily dependent on the inherent mechanics of the English language in the creation of a seamless sense of flow throughout the music, it made translating this style of music into Japanese extremely difficult due to the stark differences in how both

¹⁰ Noriko Manabe, “Globalization and Japanese Creativity: Adaptations of Japanese Language to Rap,” *Ethnomusicology* 50, no. 1 (Winter 2006): 3, 5.

languages are constructed. Specifically, Japanese artists struggled with adapting rhyme and rhythm, two essential elements of rap, to the Japanese language, meaning they had to come up with some way to manipulate the language to create a seamless flow.

The first problem that Japanese rappers ran into was finding a way to make things rhyme. For instance, Japanese rappers couldn't look to their poetry as a reference because Japanese poetry is built on syllable amounts rather than rhyming, and Japanese syntax is built such that the vast majority of sentences that can be constructed in Japanese end in very similar-sounding suffixes, like *-desu* or *-masu*, meaning that having a lot of variety in rhyming with standard Japanese syntax is essentially impossible. Thus, one of the most standard forms that were developed for creating rhymes in Japanese was breaking the syntax and reordering sentences using the idea that the most important words are put on the end of the phrase.¹¹ Noriko Manabe cites K Dub Shine's song "*Sutaa tanjou*" (Birth of a Star) (1995) as an example, specifically these lines: "*Hanashi ga chigaune shoujo no yume / Kamera no mukou de itameteru mune.*"¹² In this case, the most important words "*yume*" and "*mune*" are put at the end to create a rhyme as well as emphasize the importance of these words within the sentence. If this line was written in standard Japanese syntax, it would instead look like: "*Shoujo no yume to hanashi ga chigaune / Kamera no mukou de mune ga itameteru.*"¹³ In addition, the Japanese vocabulary is very expansive, including not only Japanese words but also Sino-Japanese compounds and loan words from other languages, making the pool of sources for rhymes in Japanese very wide.

Another problem that Japanese rappers faced was the concept of rhythm, in that Japanese is a polysyllabic language with very little stress accents, making an engaging rhythm difficult to

¹¹ Noriko Manabe, "Globalization and Japanese Creativity: Adaptations of Japanese Language to Rap," *Ethnomusicology* 50, no. 1 (Winter 2006): 3, 5.

¹² *Ibid.*, 8-9.

¹³ *Ibid.*, 9.

create. What Japanese does have, however, is basic tone melodies, which Japanese rappers capitalized on to create flow without the use of stress accents. Double consonants, nasal “N” sounds, and the ability to change the weight on certain syllabic units or save them altogether are other features of Japanese language that lend themselves well to creating flow through syncopation and irregular rhythms.¹⁴

The solutions that Japanese artists came up with to combat these problems truly shows that at this point, Japanese rap was more than just a simple copy of American rap. Granted, a lot of the elements of the production of songs within the genre itself were heavily borrowed from American rap; for example, in Amuro Namie’s 2005 video release “Space of Hip-Pop,” Namie wears a dress similar to the ones found in the Lady Marmalade video starring Pink, Christina Aguilera, Mya, and Lil’ Kim, as well as a hat looking like one worn by Alicia Keys. The choreography in this video is also similar to that in Western music videos, being composed of “pelvic thrusts and gyrations.”¹⁵ One of Namie’s songs, “Queen of Hip-Pop” (2005), exemplifies the juxtaposition of Japanese and English words common in Japanese hip-hop, and another song, “Speed Star” (2005), is about “conspicuous consumptionism,” or “pimping.”¹⁶ However, Japanese artists weren’t simply taking American ideas and repurposing them; rather, there was unique thought that went into creating the lyrics, and for as many songs that were about “American” behaviors like “pimping,” there were plenty of other songs that spoke directly about Japanese issues, much like how early American hip-hop and rap speak about issues within their own country.

¹⁴ Manabe, “Globalization and Japanese Creativity,” 17-19.

¹⁵ Yasser Mattar, “Miso Soup for the Ears: Contemporary Japanese Popular Music and its Relation to the Genres Familiar to the Anglophonic Audience,” *Popular Music and Society* 31, no. 1 (February 2008): 115.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 115.

I.4 *Shibuya-kei*: “Japanese” or “International” Music?

One of the uniquely Japanese musical genres that developed in Japan as a result of the influence of Western musicians is a genre called “*Shibuya-kei*,” literally translating to “Shibuya style.” Named for the Shibuya shopping district located in Tokyo, it emerged in the late 1980s as a sort of independent subculture of the Japanese popular music scene. Just as Shibuya is well-known as an international mecca of commerce in Japan, housing stores upon stores of some of the most recognizable worldwide brands of clothing, entertainment, and other goods, *Shibuya-kei* music similarly draws from a truly international pool of musical styles for inspiration, “fusing jazz, easy listening and bossa nova with British, American, and French retro-pop styles.”¹⁷ During the late 1980s, the fashionable Shibuya shopping district was associated with heavy consumerism of goods, especially international goods, and this very much included the consumption of music. Within Shibuya, there was a rich culture of record and album collecting, and many of the most influential names within *Shibuya-kei*, like Yasuharu Konishi and Keigo Oyamada, were “record collector[s] first and musician[s] second.”¹⁸ According to Marx, the “entire base of the music itself relied on sampling or pastiche of pre-existing media.”¹⁹ Thus, the name “*Shibuya-kei*” is fitting; it presents the music as a sort of microcosm or representation of the consumerist culture that was present in 1980s Shibuya, with the lyrics giving us a glimpse into the lives of the middle-class youth who frequented the district and engaged in this culture, but aside from this it also depicts an “ostentatious internationalism” reflected within the many styles of music that *Shibuya-kei* bands and artists drew from and referenced. This sense of nationalism was not just reflected in the music by itself, but also in the visual aspect of Shibuya-kei groups: for example,

¹⁷ Martin Roberts, “‘A new stereophonic sound spectacular’: Shibuya-kei as transnational soundscape,” *Popular Music* 32, no. 1 (January 2013): 111.

¹⁸ *Ibid.*, 113.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 113.

album covers, promotional materials, music videos, and even live performances all heavily referenced the stylings of retro-pop groups from the UK and especially France.²⁰

The main vehicle through which this sort of music had initially made its way into Japan was Mike Alway and his label *él Records*. Alway's vision for this label was that the primary audience would not be the British youth, but instead the Japanese youth, and the artists that were signed to the label were marketed and styled to appeal specifically to that audience. As a result, *él Records* enjoyed a cult following among the Japanese, and a number of early Japanese Shibuya-kei artists attribute their works to this cult following; most notably, vocalist Kahimi Karie collaborated with producer Keigo Oyamada on a song titled "Mike Alway's Diary" (1992), released in a mini-album of the same name under *Crue-L Records*, a Japanese indie label founded soon after Alway split with *él Records*. Other non-Japanese artists enjoyed popularity within this budding indie music scene, such as Philippe Auclair, one of the mainstays of *él Records* and later a producer of several albums and compilations under Oyamada's label *Trattoria*, as well as Nick Currie (a.k.a. Momus), who was based in Japan and produced songs for vocalists like Kahimi Karie and others. The budding genre of consumerist music enjoyed a cult following in countries like the United Kingdom and the United States, the very same countries that Shibuya-kei music drew inspiration from.

Another important musical influence on the sound of *Shibuya-kei* was that of Brazilian bossa nova. Just as bossa nova had experienced an earlier cult following in the United States, it had been received similarly in Japan, especially since Brazil and Japan share a lot of connections due to immigration between the two countries, with Brazil having the largest Japanese community outside of Japan itself. Brazilian artists such as Nara Leão have a large cult following

²⁰ Roberts, "A new stereophonic sound spectacular," 113-114.

and a substantial body of work has been produced by Japanese-Brazilian and Japanese artists as well. Thus, *Shibuya-kei* has also seen a sizable cult following in Brazil, much like it did in the United Kingdom and the United States. The Brazilian influence in *Shibuya-kei* goes a lot deeper than simply using ideas from bossa nova, however. Although a lot of *Shibuya-kei* music can be seen as very upbeat, reflecting the utopian nature of consumer culture and with lyrical themes tending towards indulgence and play rather than work, there is also a fair amount of nostalgia and longing within a lot of *Shibuya-kei* music. The concept of *saudade*, which came out of Brazilian bossa nova and has a similar meaning to the Japanese concept *mono no aware*, or the realization of the transience of things and the wistfulness it brings, is reflected especially in newer *Shibuya-kei* music, and provides a dichotomy between that and a lot of older, bubblier and more optimistic *Shibuya-kei*, and further reflects the international nature of this genre's conception and development.²¹

²¹ Roberts, "A new stereophonic sound spectacular," 118-120.

II. NEW JAPANESE GENRES

II.1 Chillhop, or Lo-fi Hip-hop

Earlier I discussed the emergence of Japanese hip-hop in the late 1980s and early 1990s. In addition to Japanese artists' creativity and ingenuity with regards to adapting rap and hip-hop to the Japanese language, other Japanese artists took their modifications of the genre in a different direction, focusing more on the actual sonic traits of the music, more so than the language.

Chillhop, also commonly known as lo-fi hip-hop, is a derivative of hip-hop that has grown extremely popular in recent years thanks to the Internet. Many people are likely aware of the popular YouTube stream "lofi hip hop radio - beats to relax/study to,"²² and the evidence of this channel's popularity – as of February 2nd, 2023, the channel the stream is hosted on, titled "Lofi Girl," has 11.9 million subscribers, and the stream itself, which is live 24 hours a day, has nearly 50,000 concurrent viewers²³ – is a testament to the rising popularity of chillhop music.

According to Ryan Celsius, a DJ who runs his own lo-fi hip-hop radio streams on YouTube, this renewed interest in chillhop comes from "a bygone nostalgia for Cartoon Network's Adult Swim and Toonami," especially for anime that aired on these channels such as *Cowboy Bebop* or *Samurai Champloo*.²⁴ In particular, *Samurai Champloo* was very important in bringing chillhop music to a wider audience, as much of the soundtrack consists of this kind of low-tempo, effect-heavy music. One of the main forces behind the soundtrack of *Samurai Champloo* was Seba Jun, or, as he is better known, Nujabes. An extremely influential figure in

²² Lofi Girl, "lo-fi hip hop radio - beats to relax/study to," accessed Feb. 2, 2023, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jfKfPfyJRdk>

²³ "Lofi Girl," YouTube, accessed Feb. 2, 2023, <https://www.youtube.com/c/lofigirl>.

²⁴ Luke Winkie, "How 'Lofi Hip Hop Radio to Relax/Study To' Became a Youtube Phenomenon," *Vice*, July 13, 2018, <https://www.vice.com/en/article/594b3z/how-lofi-hip-hop-radio-to-relaxstudy-to-became-a-youtube-phenomenon>.

the chillhop scene, with some even going so far as to call him the “godfather” of chillhop, his music has become extremely popular with listeners in recent years and continues to serve as a major source of inspiration for many artists involved in the scene, as well as for many artists outside the scene.

Very little is known about Nujabes’ life outside of his career, but we know that he was intimately connected with the Japanese music scene even before his musical career launched, being the owner of T Records and Guinness Records in Shibuya.²⁵ His musical career began in 1998 with the release of his mixtape “Sweet Sticky Thing” as well as the foundation of his label, Hydeout Productions.²⁶ He continued to release numerous EPs and singles, as well as collaborating with other artists, the most notable of which being the “Luv(sic) Hexalogy” (2015), which he worked on with Shing02 throughout his life.²⁷ In 2003, he released his first studio album titled *Metaphorical Music*,²⁸ and his second album, *Modal Soul*, was released soon after in 2005.²⁹ However, as mentioned before, it was likely his work on *Samurai Champloo* in 2004 that is most recognized today.³⁰ Nujabes died unexpectedly in 2010, much to the shock of his collaborators and other artists in the hip-hop scene in both Japan and across the world. His work continues to be celebrated, with the creation of tribute albums such as *25 Nights for Nujabes* (2018) by Australian producer Ta-ku, as well as shoutouts by various rappers in their own music, expressing their appreciation for the legacy he left behind.³¹

²⁵ Lucy Dayman, “Nujabes: The Japanese Icon Who Shaped the Future of Hip Hop,” *Culture Trip*, November 14, 2019, <https://theculturetrip.com/asia/japan/articles/nujabes-the-japanese-icon-who-shaped-the-future-of-hip-hop/>.

²⁶ Nujabes, *Sweet Sticky Thing*, 1998, cassette

²⁷ Nujabes feat. Shing02, *Luv(sic) Hexalogy*, Hydeout Productions HPD18, 2015, compact disc.

²⁸ Nujabes, *Metaphorical Music*, Dimid Recordings DMDCD-0008, 2003, compact disc

²⁹ Nujabes, *Modal Soul*, Hydeout Productions HPD5, 2005, compact disc

³⁰ “Nujabes,” in *Audiophile’s Guide to Trip Hop Musicians* (Raleigh: lulu.com, 2015), 139.

³¹ Ta-ku, *25 Nights for Nujabes*, Jakarta Records, 2018, lossless digital, <https://takukaflip.bandcamp.com/album/25-nights-for-nujabes>.

II.1.1 A Case Study of Nujabes' Chillhop Production Through "Aruarian Dance" and Other Songs

During Nujabes' career, the genre denomination that we currently refer to as "chillhop" did not exist, and yet, he is often credited as being one of the forerunners of this genre due to a unique production style that set him apart from other hip-hop artists. Nujabes' production style can be described as a fusion of different musical influences such as house music, jazz fusion, and of course, hip-hop.³² Many of Nujabes' tracks contain a drum beat that constantly repeats throughout the track, an absolutely essential element of hip-hop music, which is then embellished by various short instrumental phrases or by a rapper's rhymes. In addition, Nujabes often employs a production technique referred to as sampling, or taking an existing recording, be it another song or simply voice recordings, and using it as part of a new song, which was an extremely common technique in the Western hip-hop scene as well. What sets Nujabes apart from other hip-hop artists, however, is his instrument selection and, as a result, the vibe that his music creates.

As mentioned before, Nujabes' music has a strong jazz influence, and this can be observed in his choice of instruments. For example, in the track "Summer Gypsy" from *Metaphorical Music* (2003), several instrumental phrases played on instruments such as saxophones, muted trumpets, trombones, and vibraphones can be heard; all of these instruments can be found in a typical jazz orchestra.³³ Instrumental phrases akin to improvisational jazz solos are also common in many of Nujabes' other tracks. Where tracks from other hip-hop artists, especially those from the West, have a certain sound to them that can be described as loud or

³² Mosi Reeves, "How Shing02 and Nujabes Linked West Coast and Japanese Hip-Hop," *KQED*, Mar. 28, 2020, <https://www.kqed.org/arts/13877640/how-shing02-and-nujabes-linked-west-coast-and-japanese-hip-hop>.

³³ Nujabes, "Summer Gypsy," track 13 on *Metaphorical Music*, Dimid Recordings DMDCD-0008, 2003, compact disc.

harsh, his music is instead described as having “a mellow, nostalgic, and atmospheric sound,” as well as “a soothing vibe.”³⁴

Another track that exemplifies Nujabes’ unique production style described above is “Aruarian Dance,” the third track on the collection *Samurai Champloo Music Record: Departure* (2004), consisting of tracks from the anime of the same name.³⁵ The track starts off with a solo guitar phrase that evokes a kind of somber, lonely feeling, setting the tone for the rest of the track. Soon after, the drumbeat starts, adding another layer to the track but still keeping it low tempo and low energy. Occasionally, there are also orchestral string swells that emerge at the ends of phrases that infuse the track with emotional color. Around the middle of the track, the guitar takes a back seat to a synth lead that sounds quite similar to a flute. The second half of the track uses the same guitar phrase as the first half, but this time it’s heavily effected to make it sound muffled and without any articulation, almost as if one were listening to it underwater. These kinds of repeated phrases are very typical of hip-hop as a whole, and especially so of chillhop as well.

To include a slightly different example, “Luv(sic.) pt3” from *Modal Soul* (2005) shows an example of Nujabes’ production that isn’t strictly instrumental. Similarities can be seen with this track and “Aruarian Dance,” namely that the drumbeat takes center stage within the mix, the instrumentation aside from the drumbeat is sparse, and the melodic phrases used within the track are all very simple lines that are repeated throughout the track with slight variations each time. Before Shing02 takes over with his rapping, Nujabes utilizes sampled recordings and the sound of record scratching to enter the track. The lyrics of this track seem to be melancholic, but also

³⁴ “Nujabes,” in *Audiophile’s Guide*, 139.

³⁵ Nujabes, “Aruarian Dance,” track 3 on *Samurai Champloo Music Record: Departure*, Victor Entertainment VICL-61411, 2004, compact disc.

tinged with a sense of hope for the future and the chance to start things over. This is reflected in the music by the reverberating piano sound paired with the orchestral-sounding synth pads flowing throughout the bottom of the track during the chorus. All of these elements come together to create a track with the kind of “mellow, nostalgic, and atmospheric sound” that Nujabes is known for.

II.2 Japanese City Pop

The genre of music referred to as “Japanese city pop” that developed in the mid-1980s shares a great number of similarities with *Shibuya-kei*, especially lending to the fact that many of the elements present within both genres – musical, visual, and textual – have a transnational aspect to them. Musically, Japanese city pop draws an influence from a myriad of genres; according to Moritz Sommet, it “blends elements from so many various existing (and often more clearly defined) popular music genres that it has hardly developed a musical identity of its own.”³⁶ There is a lot of overlap between the genres that spawned city pop and those that spawned *Shibuya-kei*, and as a result, musically the two genres sound very similar and have a similar transnationality to them. Visually, the cover art of city pop albums often contains elements such as city skylines, beaches, or pools, among many other landscapes that evoke a sense of luxury or sophistication that is often associated with affluence and growing consumerism in Japan, especially during this time period. This same sense is present within the visual design of *Shibuya-kei*, an important distinction being that it was more often expressed through the fashion of the band members that posed for promotional media and performed at concerts. In both cases, there is a metropolitan aesthetic to both city pop and *Shibuya-kei* that reflects an aspiration towards the urban West.

³⁶ Moritz Sommet, “Intermediality and the discursive construction of popular music genres: the case of Japanese city pop,” *Journal of Handai Music Studies* 16/17 (2020); 21.

Textually, a great number of city pop songs express youthful passions and leisure, with lyrics telling of events ranging from a fun day at the beach to the melancholic feelings of lost love. City pop songs often incorporate code switching into their lyrics, meaning that singers will sing in Japanese, but will also frequently transition to using words from English or other foreign languages for certain words or lines either for the purpose of creating end rhymes or for creating a certain mood that is enhanced by the use of these foreign words. This is a technique commonly used in Japanese popular music, but especially so in the genres of city pop and *Shibuya-kei* where the transnational influence is especially prominent.

As mentioned previously, city pop draws from a variety of genres, many of which ultimately overlap with *Shibuya-kei*. The genre is very loosely defined and draws from many different Western genres, including “pop, disco, funk, R&B, boogie, jazz fusion, Latin, Caribbean, and Polynesian music,” and because of this city pop tracks can sound wildly different from one another. For example, Masayoshi Takanaka’s “Bamboo Vender” (1979)³⁷ is described as “a lush, tropical romp” while Minako Yoshida’s “Midnight Driver” (1980)³⁸ is described as “a thumping rug-cutter.”³⁹ Some songs classified as city pop can be slow, powerful ballads about love and loss, while others can be upbeat dance numbers about a bright summer day. With such a variety of musical genres that it draws from, city pop spans a vast gamut of tones and moods, and as a result it is very difficult to pick out specific musical characteristics that truly define “city pop” as a musical genre. However, one especially common characteristic shared among many city pop songs is their instrumentation; they often employ large horn sections akin to big band

³⁷ Masayoshi Takanaka, “Bamboo Vender,” track B2 on *Jolly Jive*, Kitty Records MKF 1055, 1979, vinyl.

³⁸ Minako Yoshida, “Midnight Driver,” track B3 on *MONOCHROME*, Alfa ALR-28006, 1980, vinyl.

³⁹ Jon Blistein, “City Pop: Why Does the Soundtrack to Tokyo’s Tech Boom Still Resonate?” *Rolling Stone*, May 2, 2019, https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-features/japanese-city-pop-returns-light-in-the-attic-compilation-pacific-breeze-822663/?sub_action=logged_in.

jazz orchestras, a typical guitar-bass-drums three-piece band, and more often than not they may also include Latin percussion and synthesizers, truly showing the diversity of the music that influenced city pop artists.

Because genre specifications are often created retroactively, it is difficult to trace the exact roots of the genre itself, but it is likely that it formed as an offshoot of “new music,” which is “a singer-songwriter based genre that had emerged in the mid- to late 1970s,” but with a more “urban feeling,” as Kiyokazu Tōno describes in an article on “city music” in 1977.⁴⁰ The term “city music,” and thus “city pop” itself likely comes in part from the band Happy End’s album *CITY* (1973), even though the music of Happy End has few similarities with the music of city pop.⁴¹ After the band’s breakup, the members of Happy End would go on to produce and compose more music, both inside the city pop genre and outside it, as well as create other groups of their own. Around this time, the short-lived band Sugar Babe was formed by Eiichi Ohtaki, a former member of Happy End, as well as musician and composer Tatsuro Yamashita and vocalist Taeko Ohnuki, before they broke up in 1976. By this point, the foundations of the city pop genre had been established, and both Happy End and Sugar Babe paved the way for artists like Mariya Takeuchi, Miki Matsubara, and others to launch their careers. City pop reached the peak of its popularity in the early to mid-1980s during Japan’s economic bubble, the height of decadence and affluence in Japan, where it reached an audience of young urbanites who had plenty of luxury. By the 1990s, however, as the economy had slowly been on the decline, the genre was already on its way out, and filling its place would be *Shibuya-kei* music. Within the past several years, however, the genre has seen a resurgence in popularity thanks to the YouTube

⁴⁰ Kiyokazu Tōno, quoted in Sommet, “Intermediality,” 24.

⁴¹ Happy End, *CITY - Happy End Best Album*, Bellwood Records OFL-15, 1973, vinyl.

algorithm, and other modern Japanese artists continue to keep the essence of city pop alive, including the likes of producer tofubeats and vocalists Hitomitoi and Toki Asako.

II.2.1 The Music of Tatsuro Yamashita

As mentioned before, Yamashita was very active within the city pop scene, both in producing music for other vocalists and composing music to perform himself. According to the discography on Yamashita's official website, he has released twenty-nine solo albums and many more singles over a career spanning nearly fifty years.⁴² Of these albums, *Ride on Time* (1980)⁴³ and *For You* (1982)⁴⁴ are likely the most well known by Western audiences. To illustrate the spectrum of moods and influences present within city pop music, we will focus on several tracks from *For You*.

The opener of this album, "Sparkle," is true to its name: an upbeat tune that exhibits the playful side of city pop music. Yamashita employs dense orchestration including a big band-esque horn section along with a four-piece band, as well as dense vocals with his voice being supported by a backing chorus. The tone of the instruments used is very bright and clear, possibly attempting to convey the sun shining down on a summer's day, or the transparency of the water crashing along the shores. The party atmosphere of the track is further amplified in the instrumental break, with a screaming saxophone solo to bring the energy up. The song eventually cools down with the repeated chanting of "Wonder in the world" and "Sparkle in my heart" for an uplifting finish. From this song, one can easily discern the jazz and funk influences on Japanese city pop music.

⁴² "Discography," Tatsuro Yamashita Official Website, accessed May 1, 2023, <https://www.tatsuro.co.jp/discography/>.

⁴³ Tatsuro Yamashita, *Ride on Time*, Air Records RAL-8501, 1980, vinyl.

⁴⁴ Tatsuro Yamashita, *For You*, Air Records RAL-8801, 1982, vinyl.

On the other hand, “Futari” represents the opposite end of this spectrum, being a slow, powerful ballad about a couple finding peace in the fact that they are together. This song starts out quietly, with a piano solo evoking the image of a near-empty jazz club at night, a space in which the lovers can be together alone. As Yamashita continues to sing, the track builds in intensity until it reaches the climax in the chorus, where Yamashita is belting with a strong chorus sound behind him; all the while the drums, guitar, and piano continue their laid-back playing. This song shows the influence of both smooth jazz and rhythm and blues on city pop music.

II.2.2 The Visual Aesthetic of Japanese City Pop

Although it has been said that the musical influences on Japanese city pop are greatly varied, the visual aesthetic of the genre is, in contrast, strongly unified and recognizable. As a product of the economic boom in Japan that resulted in a short era of luxury and decadence among young urbanites, many of the visual media that was produced to accompany city pop music reflected this with bright and vibrantly colored landscapes featuring elements such as cars, beaches, and city skylines. One of the most prolific and recognizable artists associated with the city pop aesthetic is Hiroshi Nagai, who is famous for producing the artwork that adorns many famous city pop records such as *The September Wind* (1982)⁴⁵ by Naoya Matsuoka and Wesing, and *A Long Vacation* (1981)⁴⁶ by Eiichi Ohtaki. Nagai’s artwork seems to be the perfect fit for city pop, as much of his artwork focuses on typical American-looking summer landscapes with clear, cloudless skies, sandy beaches lined with palm trees, the deep blue water of the swimming pools and the ocean, or the vibrant lights of the city at night. All of these are painted in a way that

⁴⁵ Naoya Matsuoka and Wesing, *The September Wind*, Warner Bros. Records M-6006, 1982, vinyl.

⁴⁶ Eiichi Ohtaki, *A Long Vacation*, Niagara Records 27AH 1234, 1981, vinyl.

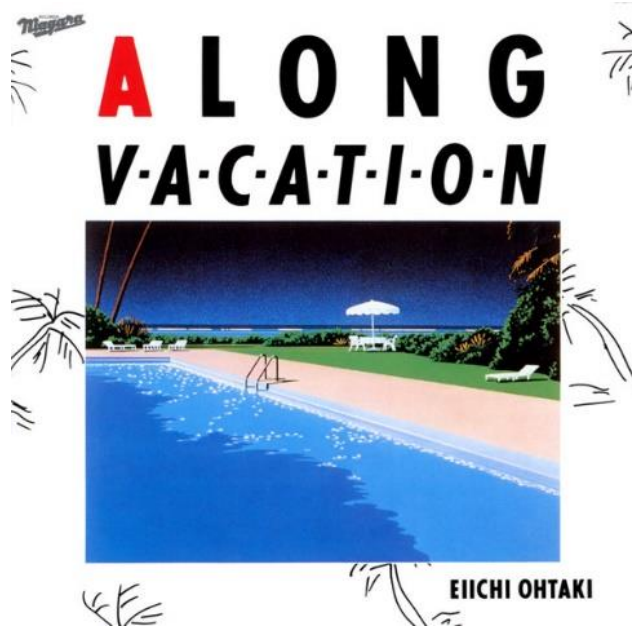


Illustration 2: Hiroshi Nagai, *A Long Vacation*, album cover, Discogs, May 1, 2023, <https://www.discogs.com/release/10883084-Eiichi-Ohtaki-A-Long-Vacation/image/SW1hZ2U6MzA0MTYxNjE=>.

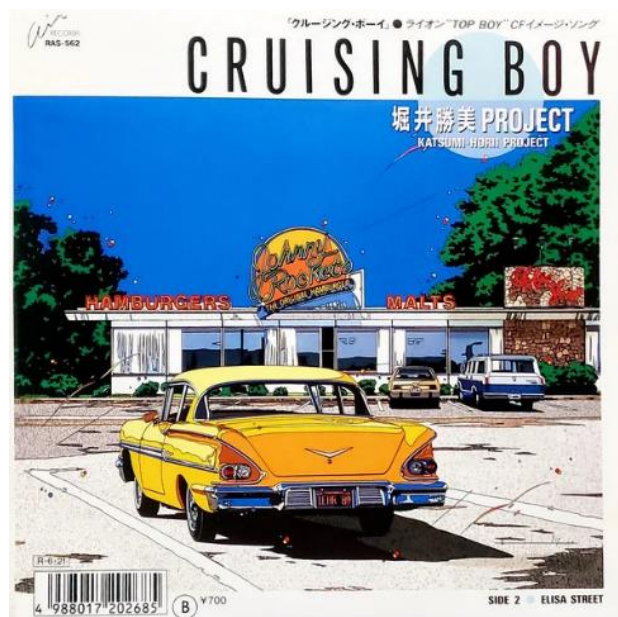


Illustration 1: Eizin Suzuki, *Cruising Boy*, album cover, Discogs, May 1, 2023, <https://www.discogs.com/master/1758157-Horii-Katsumi-Project-Cruising-Boy/image/SW1hZ2U6NDcxNzE3ODI=>.

makes it all seem unreal and “plastic,” almost like a landscape of miniature figurines, thanks to the sheer vibrancy of the colors and the uniformity of the textures. In this way, Nagai’s artwork reflects a lot of the prominent aspects of city pop music, namely the carefree nature of the lyrics,

the upbeat composition, and a general sense of leisure and summertime fun. Nagai himself cites his inspirations for his artistic style as stemming from two specific events: an exhibition on photorealism and a tour of the United States. Nagai says in an interview with Uniqlo:

“At the photorealism exhibition, I was confronted with something utterly unlike the Japanese realism that I’d seen at exhibitions like the Nitten (Japan Fine Arts Exhibition)... It was a shock. Even the subjects in the landscapes—beaches and American cars—were different. In Japanese art, you’re more likely to see Mt. Fuji. Then I went on this trip, and I got to see those very same landscapes laid out in front of my eyes. That was really exciting.”⁴⁷

However, as mentioned before, his work often tends to stray from the photorealism he describes. He states that he used landscape photos from travel fliers as reference photos, and he would then “use light and shadow to make them feel more like the landscapes that [he has] seen in person.”⁴⁸

Another artist responsible for defining the city pop visual aesthetic is Eizin Suzuki. Much like Nagai, Suzuki’s art also features many of the elements common in city pop art, especially cars and beaches. Suzuki’s art differs, however, in that it is often more detailed and more brightly colored, whereas Nagai’s art may be more simplistic and have more subdued colors. For example, Suzuki’s art adorns the covers of albums such as *For You* (1982)⁴⁹ by Tatsuro Yamashita and *Cruising Boy* (1988)⁵⁰ by the Horii Katsumi Project. The latter example in particular is characteristic of Suzuki’s style of brightly colored, highly detailed and textured art.

II.3 Japanese Noise Music, or “Japanoise”

It is difficult to say whether Japanese noise music (or noise music as a whole, for that matter) can truly be classified as “popular” music. The genre in itself is highly experimental and avant-garde,

⁴⁷ “Exploring artist Hiroshi Nagai’s work, featuring deep blue skies, sunshine, and sunsets,” *UTmagazine*, June 29, 2022, <https://www.uniqlo.com/jp/en/contents/feature/ut-magazine/s137/>.

⁴⁸ “Exploring Nagai’s work.”

⁴⁹ Tatsuro Yamashita, *For You*.

⁵⁰ Horii Katsumi Project, *Cruising Boy*, Air Records RAS-562, 1988, vinyl.

and the average listener typically won't be listening to noise music at the same frequency as they would with other genres. However, noise music has a very active – albeit underground – audience and community, and it is at the very least recognized by the general public. In his book *Japanoise*, Novak argues that around the 1990s, “Japanese music had finally become a force in North American media, and Noise was rapidly becoming known as its central genre.”⁵¹ Thus, Japanese noise music, or “Japanoise,” can be considered one of the first forms of Japanese music to even make its way overseas.

Japanoise developed in the late 1970s, emerging from the same sort of experimentation with sound that was being done by Japanese Fluxus groups, most notably *Group Ongaku*. *Group Ongaku's* music was created using both musical instruments as well as more “unorthodox sounds such as vacuum cleaners, radio static, and kitchenware, all at a sped up tempo.”⁵² Where *Group Ongaku* was more closely related to Minimalism and contemporary art, however, the Japanoise acts which would develop later tended to take a different direction towards more aggressive styles of music. An important example of such an act was the noise group *Hijokaidan*. The group originally began as a punk band under the name *Rasenkaidan*, but after further experimentation with their sound and the incorporation of improvisation and other techniques inspired by free jazz into their performance, they changed their name in 1979 and relaunched themselves as a noise group.⁵³ In the same year, Masami Akita began his own noise project *Merzbow*, which is now considered the most well-known noise act across the entire world. In subsequent years, more noise acts such as *Incapacitants*, *C.C.C.C.*, and *Masonna* would continue to pop up in Japan's underground music scene as people continued to experiment with sound.

⁵¹ David Novak, *Japanoise: Music at the Edge of Circulation* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013), 10.

⁵² Kade Nations, “Distortion and Destruction: A Deep Dive into Japanese Noise Music,” *Sabukaru*, Aug. 10, 2021, <https://sabukaru.online/articles/distortion-amp-destruction-a-deep-look-into-japanese-noise-music>.

⁵³ Ibid.

II.3.1 The Music of Merzbow

“Merzbow” is the name of Masami Akita’s noise project, and it comes from dada artist Kurt Schwitters’ artwork titled *Merzbau*, which was a work of “junk art” that was constantly being added to and changed until there was little room for anything else. In choosing this name, Merzbow recontextualizes his project as not simply noise music, but also as dada-inspired works of art. Merzbow explains that his music is made “only by noises and sounds generated solely by non-instruments.”⁵⁴ In this way, Merzbow’s music is akin to the sound equivalent of junk art.

Upon listening to “Woodpecker No. 1” from *Pulse Demon* (1996),⁵⁵ one is treated to nearly seven minutes of consistent harsh noise. What’s interesting, though, is that the noise itself is not simply an ear-splitting drone, however, throughout the track there is a surprising amount of variance within the noises that are happening. All of these noises had to be created in different ways, so how were they created? The album’s credits contain a short list of equipment that Merzbow used, including metals, noise electronics, audio generators, shortwaves, EMS, tapes, and voice.⁵⁶ Knowing this, one can listen to the track trying to figure out how Merzbow created these sounds. Alternatively, you could enjoy it based on feeling alone. Merzbow has stated that he believes “music is perceived intuitively on presence, and that’s the way it should be.”⁵⁷

II.3.2 Performing Noise Music

An absolutely essential aspect to noise music, especially in Japan, is its performance. Noise music developed through a circuit of Japanese “livehouses,” which are smaller, more intimate

⁵⁴ “Fifteen Questions with MERZBOW,” Fifteen Questions, accessed May 1, 2023, <https://15questions.net/interview/fifteen-questions-merzbow/page-1/>.

⁵⁵ Merzbow, *Pulse Demon*, Relapse Records RR 6937-2, 1998, compact disc.

⁵⁶ “Merzbow – Pulse Demon (1998, CD),” Discogs, accessed May 1, 2023, <https://www.discogs.com/release/1817840-Merzbow-Pulse-Demon>.

⁵⁷ “Fifteen Questions with MERZBOW.”

concert venues akin to clubs. As a result, noise music has extremely strong ties to the live music scene, and many noise artists compose their music with the intention of performing it live, first and foremost. The character of noise performances can vary wildly, ranging from a person calmly sitting at a table full of various types of electronic equipment, operating it all with a choreographed efficiency, to a group of people creating an atmosphere of pure chaos, with “mass destruction, debris, trash and bags of human waste being flung around the venue and into the crowd, and on stage urination all being prevalent.”⁵⁸ In some rare cases, musicians took their performance to the absolute extreme, to the point that almost every Japanese venue had banned them from performing, as was the case with Yamantaka Eye, the front man of noise groups *Hanatarash* and *Boredoms*.⁵⁹ In one particularly infamous incident, during a *Hanatarash* set, Eye drove into the back of the live house they were performing in with a bulldozer, destroying it. All of these different forms of performance constitute what Novak considers “getting into the music,” which is important in the enjoyment of noise music.

However, what’s important to note is that despite the kind of violence associated with noise music performances that I have just described, these performers (to my knowledge) do not aim to promote or endorse violence within ordinary life. Offstage, the performers are often just regular people. An example of such a phenomenon can be seen within the group *Incapacitants*, whose “[exceeding] mundaneness” is legendary among Japanoise fans, according to Novak. Toshiji Mikawa, for example, “works a bureaucratic job in a major Japanese bank...commutes to work from a suburban home, [and] he coaches his children’s soccer league,” while his band mate, Fumio Kosakai, works in a government office.⁶⁰ Onstage, however, *Incapacitants*

⁵⁸ Nations, “Distortion and Destruction.”

⁵⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁰ Novak, “Japanoise,” 40, 42.

performances often consist of “tiny Mikawa spasming and collapsing on one side of the stage, flanked by the comparatively huge Kosakai flinging his arms into the air like a giant, shaking a fed-back, wailing telephone pickup, his broad stomach shaking and vibrating.”⁶¹ This example of noise performances show that anyone can be physically affected by the “liveness” of noise music, and how that is expressed ultimately differs from person to person.

⁶¹ Ibid., 42.

III. A JAPANESE WAVE: THE GROWING POPULARITY OF JAPANESE POPULAR MUSIC IN THE WEST

III.1 The Internet's Role

At first glance, focusing solely on the musical and visual traits of the three genres discussed in the previous chapter, they couldn't be more different. However, there is one common thread that unites these genres and their increased popularity in the West: the Internet. More specifically, it's thanks in part to YouTube's recommendation algorithm and numerous forms of social media both old and new that allowed these genres' popularity to rise rapidly within the past decade. Internet users are not only involved in sharing this music, but they are also involved in the process of remixing this music to create entirely new genres of music, one such genre being vaporwave.

Vaporwave is a genre of music considered by many as one of the few musical genres to exist solely within the internet. The music itself is created by sampling music from the late 20th century, including genres such as Japanese city pop and American disco, and placing heavy effects on these songs, such as slowing it down and putting reverb on them, in order to create a sort of ethereal, dreamlike quality that is intended to evoke a further feeling of nostalgia for bygone days. Vaporwave also has a strong visual element to it, drawing from a similar sort of vibrant color palette as was common in city pop art, albeit with many of the hues leaning more to the pastel side. Vaporwave albums and song titles often use Japanese words, many of which end up being results of erroneous machine translations. The most well-known vaporwave song, Macintosh Plus' “リサフランク 420 / 現代のコンピュー” from the album *Floral Shoppe*

(2011),⁶² for example, samples Diana Ross' song "It's Your Move," slowing it down to about 0.75x speed, pitching it down, and adding effects to it to create that dreamlike quality. The album art of *Floral Shoppe* also contributes to that quality, with its pink background and a Greco-Roman bust placed next to a picture of a bay with VHS-like film grain overlaid on top.

III.2 Western Musicians Influenced by Japanese Popular Music

It's no secret that aspects of Japanese culture have influenced Western artists in various mediums. As an example, Vincent Van Gogh was influenced by Japanese *ukiyo-e* and painted multiple paintings based on that influence. Western animators continue to be influenced by Japanese *anime*, adopting techniques they learn by observing. It is the case, then, that the three musical genres I have discussed in this paper have also influenced Western musicians.

If you want to find a testament to chillhop's popularity, look no further than Lofi Girl. As I discussed earlier, the channel has over ten million subscribers, and the 24-hour stream hosted on that channel averages 50,000 concurrent viewers at peak hours. The stream itself plays music from a collection of over 1,000 lo-fi hip hop tracks, all of which are made by artists across the world. The influence of Nujabes specifically on hip hop music in the West, let alone chillhop music in the West cannot be understated. Nujabes has received numerous shoutouts from rappers especially since his passing, acknowledging his contributions to the genre. Certain artists have also created tribute project for Nujabes, a notable example of this being *25 Nights for Nujabes* (2018)⁶³ by Australian producer Ta-ku. Among the tracks in this album, a track called "Night 5" is one that I feel carries a lot of Nujabes' influence, especially that of "Aruarian Dance." The track has a lot of that same somber feeling, with the drumbeat taking center stage and the

⁶² Macintosh Plus, *Floral Shoppe*, Beer On The Rug BOTR009, 2011, MP3 file.

⁶³ Ta-ku, *25 Nights for Nujabes*.

emotional color enhanced by synth sounds as well as a bass clarinet providing a simple melody line with swells.

The historical context from which city pop was born in Japan is not easily replicated, but city pop-styled tracks in the West instead fall back on a feeling of nostalgia for that era. One such project is Ginger Root, an alias of American musician Cameron Lew that aims to recreate the visual and auditory aesthetic of 1980s Japan. For example, in his song “Loretta,” one of the actors in the music video is watching Ginger Root sing on an old-style TV, and the entire music video has a similar grain and “glowy” appearance that’s common among CRTs and other TVs that were available at the time. The music is also put through a compression filter in order to make it sound as if it was coming from a 1980s speaker as well. Aside from the nostalgic design choices, the actual song is very funk-sounding and uses a lot of similar instrumentation to the music of Tatsuro Yamashita that I discussed earlier, as well as employing Latin percussion. Ginger Root’s newest song “Nisemono” has a similar feeling to it, although it also employs a lot of electronic synth sounds as well, but the funk sound and the nostalgic aesthetic choices are still very much present.

In the case of noise music, however, there is the issue that it developed across the world at the same time, and due to its nature as “experimental music,” it would be extremely difficult to trace specific similarities across Japanese noise music and Western noise music. Similarities do exist between these two forms of noise music in that the punk flavor that makes up an important part of Japanese noise music also exists in Western noise music, however, there are also important differences. Novak notes that in a performance context, Japanese noise musicians have the ability to produce overwhelming volume because the performers often have the full support of the staff at the livehouse, whereas noise musicians in the West are limited by nonprofessional

venues, underpowered equipment, and disagreements between the performers and staff about volume that, in some cases, lead to physical confrontation.⁶⁴ Despite these differences, cross-cultural collaborations can often exhibit a kind of chemistry that exists between the collaborators; for example, “Oumagatoki” (2004)⁶⁵ by Merzbow + The New Blockaders is (at the risk of sounding oxymoronic) a very atmospheric noise track, where the two different ideas of noise music merge very well together.

With all this said, it still seems that it will take much more time for these connections to become much more apparent, similar to how it took nearly thirty years for Japanese music to become fully fleshed-out adaptations of Western music. This phenomenon is still in its infancy, so if this idea is revisited once more after a decade or so, the Japanese wave may have finally settled, and one may find even more connections between Japanese and Western popular musics.

⁶⁴ Novak, *Japanoise*, 37.

⁶⁵ Merzbow + The New Blockaders, *Oumagatoki*, Hypnagogia nag03, 2004, vinyl.

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